PLACE Making Team Aboriculture

Development Management Consultation Response

Date: 23 September 2024

Reference:	Site:	Proposal:	Case Officer:
S/RES/24/0947	Parcels R6 And R7 Land North Of A420 Swindon	A reserved matters application (access, appearance, layout, scale and landscaping) for 137 dwellings and associated infrastructure - Reserved Matters from previous outline permission S/OUT/13/1555.	Ed Snook
Summary of response			
		No Comment/No Objection	☐
		Information required	☒
		Objection - changes required	☒
		Objection in principle	☐
Executive Summary			

Full Comments

The application is supported by a suite of landscape drawings (IDP drg nos. IDPL LA5979-BP-400 to 403, all Rev A), a planning layout (Stantec ref. 333100151_PL-03) and various other plans including an engineering layout (Rappor drg no. 240616-RAP-XX-XX-DR-C-0100 Rev P01) and various cross-sectional drawings. There is no arboricultural assessment or data presented.

I note the comments from the council's landscape officer (memorandum dated 03/09/2024) and agree with the proposed species' size and longevity concerns (point 11), the conflict with the tree and boundary wall (point 6), the improved arrangement for the planting adjacent to the parking bays (point 12 and the improvement to the proposed tree offer generally across the site (point 8).

There are a number of potential conflict areas between the existing trees and the proposed layout. As this is a reserved matters application, it is appropriate to consider these at this this stage: the trees (and hedgerow) adjacent to the head of the cul-de-sac (road 11) between plots 70 and 91; the visitor parking spaces west of 76 to 78; the dwelling footprint within plot 75 and; the drain through the centre of the hedge along the southern boundary. It is likely that the root protection areas of the respective trees and hedges are compromised and information is needed to accurately assess the short and long term implications. Some of the conflicts may well be resolvable with appropriate mitigation, without a change in the design, but others may require a more fundamental amendment. Information, consistent with

BS5837:2012, should be submitted to demonstrate that the trees indicated on the plans as being retained can be done so in practice.

Several areas within the layout do not appear to be consistent with the approved strategic design code or the character area design code. The in-parcel tree strategy promotes the use of species that are larger at maturity where space permits and, as noted by my landscape colleague, there are spaces that would benefit from this approach within the scheme. The character area design code produced a vision diagram that mapped out a landscape-led gateway either side of the Primary Street in the southeast part of the site. Despite this also featuring on the Regulating Plan, the connection of the Primary Street and site entrance is afforded a very underwhelming gateway. Within the Primary Street coding instructions, the verges should contain tree planting that alternates side to create a slight deviation in the traffic flow and to control vehicle speed. Whilst there are some trees shown on alternate sides of the road, the submitted landscape scheme portrays them as merely end stops to visitor parking bays. This is in direct contrast to the indicative axonometric view of the Primary Street frontage, presented as a component of the mandatory coding plan within the character area design code. The character area is also aimed at managing how the on-street continuous parking spaces should be broken up by tree planting but the spaces in front of plots 63 to 84 seem not to comply.

As my landscape colleague has identified, there is no tree pit construction information and this will need to be provided. Details should be included as to how the provision of sufficient soil for the relevant species into maturity can be met whilst adhering to the requirements of the council's highway team in respect of construction within, or adjacent to, the carriageway.

I look forward to commenting further, once additional information is presented to address the issues raised above.